with me. He invariably came top in History and grew up to be a successful political speechwriter.

These were the great people who made a great school.

In my first year at Affies, there was a general expectation that I would focus on tennis and follow in the footsteps of old boys such as Danie Visser and Johan Kriek, both of whom had enjoyed successful careers on the professional circuit. Johan had risen to No. 7 in the world in 1984 and Danie was ranked as the No. 1 doubles player in the world in 1990. Our excellent coach, Oom Theuns van Rensburg, wanted to steer me in the same direction.

Ever eager to please, I played for Affies in a tennis match against Grey College, Bloemfontein, but even by then my focus had started to shift towards the broader appeal of team sports, to the boys who were walking past the tennis courts, laughing and joking with each other on the way to rugby training.

They seemed to be having so much more fun.

I decided to stop playing tennis and turned to rugby, believing my success at primary school would continue.

Following extensive trials, the Under-14 rugby teams were listed and pinned to a noticeboard.

What? Really?

Surely there is a mistake?

There is a De Villiers in the Under-14F team ... the F team! Is that me? Could it be another De Villiers? I checked all the lists. There was no De Villiers in a higher team. That De Villiers was me ... in the F team.

I did manage to play a few matches for the Under-15E team the following year but I was disappointed and, in my Under-16 year, I chose to play hockey instead of rugby. That decision might not sound like the greatest example of 'Affie guts', but I was not getting anywhere on the rugby field and so I sought another option. Apparently stuck in a traffic jam in one sport, I decided to take a detour and seek another route to success.